SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #40 · FORGIVENESS

“Forgiving means pretending it didn’t hurt.”

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Where it often comes from

Being told to “just get over it” when you were hurt. Family rules that said not to talk about painful things. Pressure to look peaceful and spiritual. Fear that admitting pain means you are bitter. Seeing forgiveness only as a quick, cheerful act instead of an honest process.

What Scripture teaches

Real forgiveness starts by honestly naming the wrong. Joseph told his brothers plainly that they had intended evil against him, and then he forgave them. David poured out the pain of betrayal by a close friend. God keeps track of your tears. Even Jesus, as He forgave from the cross, did not pretend the cross was not happening. Forgiveness does not deny the hurt; it chooses to release the debt to God while still feeling the loss.

> *“As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people”* **(Genesis 50:20)**.

Also see

> “For it is not an enemy who insults me; that I could endure. It is not a foe who rises against me; from him I could hide. But it is you, a man like myself, my companion and close friend. We shared sweet fellowship together; we walked with the crowd into the house of God” **(Psalm 55:12–14)**.

> “You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?” **(Psalm 56:8)**.

> “Then Jesus said, ‘Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.’ And they divided up His garments by casting lots” **(Luke 23:34)**.

> “When they heaped abuse on Him, He did not retaliate; when He suffered, He made no threats, but entrusted Himself to Him who judges justly” **(1 Peter 2:23)**.

Common self-statements

- If I’ve forgiven, I shouldn’t still hurt.
- Talking about the pain means I’m bitter.
- I have to act like it was no big deal.
- Christians should get over things quickly.
- Admitting it hurt would make me unforgiving.
- If I still feel sad, I haven’t really forgiven.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must either feel no pain or not have forgiven.
- **Denial:** Pretending a real wound is not there.
- **Should statements:** “I should be over this by now.”
- **Confusing feelings with choices:** Thinking forgiveness is a feeling rather than a decision.

Challenging questions

- Did Joseph pretend his brothers had not hurt him?
- What did David do with the pain of betrayal?
- What does it mean that God keeps my tears in His bottle?
- Is forgiveness a feeling or a choice to release a debt?
- Can I still feel sad and have forgiven?
- Who taught me that admitting pain is unforgiving?
- What would honest forgiveness look like for me?

Truth summary

> Forgiving does not mean pretending it didn't hurt. I can name the wrong honestly, feel the pain, and still choose to release the debt to God. God sees my tears and cares about my wounds. Forgiveness is a choice I may need to make again and again as the hurt heals.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgive
- Sorrow
- Grief
- Peace
- Vengeance

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Forgiving means pretending it didn't hurt"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Forgiving means pretending it didn't hurt." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Joseph pretend he wasn't hurt?
- ☐ What did David do with betrayal?
- ☐ What does God do with my tears?
- ☐ Is forgiveness a feeling or a choice?
- ☐ Can I still feel sad and have forgiven?
- ☐ What would honest forgiveness look like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can name the hurt honestly and still forgive.
- ☐ God sees and keeps my tears.
- ☐ Forgiveness is a choice, not a feeling.
- ☐ I can release the debt and still grieve the loss.
- ☐ I can entrust the one who hurt me to God, who judges justly.
- ☐ Healing takes time, and that is okay.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Genesis 50:20**
  "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people."
- [ ] **Psalm 55:12–14**
  "For it is not an enemy who insults me; that I could endure. It is not a foe who rises against me; from him I could hide. But it is you, a man like myself, my companion and close friend. We shared sweet fellowship together; we walked with the crowd into the house of God."
- [ ] **Psalm 56:8**
  "You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?"
- [ ] **Luke 23:34**
  "Then Jesus said, 'Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.' And they divided up His garments by casting lots."
- [ ] **1 Peter 2:23**
  "When they heaped abuse on Him, He did not retaliate; when He suffered, He made no threats, but entrusted Himself to Him who judges justly."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Honest forgiveness journal:** Each day, write what still hurts, then write a short prayer releasing the debt to God again.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Genesis 50:20 becomes: "As for you, what you intended against **Sarah** for evil, God intended for good."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgive" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write down exactly what happened and how it hurt you,** then write, "I choose to release this debt to God."
- ☐ **Read Genesis 45 and 50,** and notice how Joseph named the wrong and still forgave.
- ☐ **Share the hurt with one safe person** without having to wrap it up neatly.
- ☐ **When the hurt returns, say:** "It still hurts, and I still choose to forgive."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Forgiving means pretending it didn't hurt": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One time I chose to forgive again
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Forgiving means pretending it didn't hurt.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You see my tears and care about my wounds. Help me reject the lie that forgiving means pretending it didn't hurt. Help me be honest about the pain, release the debt to You, and trust You with justice. Heal my heart in Your time. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.